Use ChatGPT to Sort Out What You've Been Told Before You Build a Plan

Four prompts to put the advice in one place, separate what you know from what you've assumed, list the decisions in front of you, and line up your questions for the right professionals.

Where you are

Mom needs long-term care now. The facility says one thing, a friend says another, and something you read online says a third. You're handling care decisions, money questions, and paperwork at the same time, and nobody has said what comes first.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names and account numbers removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not know your state's Medicaid rules, determine eligibility, or give legal, tax, or financial advice. Rules vary by state. Bring those questions to your Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney, or a licensed financial professional.

What you'll have at the end

You can say what you know, what you've only been told, which decisions belong to the family, and which questions go to which professional.

A one-page list: What we know, What we've been told and by whom, What we don't know, and Questions we need answered, each with who to ask.

Before you start

- Your notes on what you've been told so far and who said it, however rough.
- A rough picture of your parent's care situation and finances. Round numbers are fine.
- Any letters or notices you've received. You don't need everything.

PROMPT 1

Put everything you've been told in one place

WHY THIS MATTERS

In a care crisis, advice arrives from every direction: the facility, friends, a financial professional, an attorney, the internet. Some of it conflicts. Before you can weigh any of it, it helps to see all of it side by side, with who said what.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your notes on what you've been told so far and who said it. Don't tidy them up.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My parent needs long-term care now, and our family has been given advice from several directions. Here is what we've been told and who told us:

> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Using only what I've written, make a table with these columns: WHAT WE WERE TOLD, WHO SAID IT, WHAT IT'S ABOUT (care, money, Medicaid, legal, or the application), and DOES THIS PERSON KNOW OUR SITUATION? Then list the places where two pieces of advice disagree. Do not tell me which advice is right, and do not add Medicaid rules, numbers, or deadlines of your own. Rules vary by state, and I will check them with a professional.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The places where two people told you different things. Each one is a question to ask, not a problem to solve tonight.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Mark the disagreements. They go on your question list in the last prompt.

PROMPT 2

Separate what you know from what you've assumed

WHY THIS MATTERS

It's easy to treat something a neighbor said as settled. Seeing which parts of the picture come from a document or the person responsible, and which parts are assumptions, shows where the real gaps are.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A rough picture of your parent's care situation, finances, and anything you've learned about Medicaid so far. Round numbers are fine; leave out names and account numbers.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what our family currently understands about my parent's care situation, finances, and where things stand with Medicaid:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Do this separately for CARE, FINANCES, and MEDICAID. Sort every statement into three lists: WE KNOW THIS (we have a document, or we were told by the person responsible), WE'RE ASSUMING THIS, and WE DON'T KNOW. If I haven't said how I know something, put it under WE'RE ASSUMING THIS. Do not judge whether my parent qualifies for anything, and do not fill a gap with a general rule.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How much of the picture is sitting in the assumption lists.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Pick the assumptions you could confirm with one phone call or one document, and confirm those.

PROMPT 3

List the decisions in front of you

WHY THIS MATTERS

Some decisions belong to the family. Others carry legal or financial consequences and should wait for the right professional. Seeing the two kinds apart makes the list feel shorter.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The decisions your family thinks it is facing, in any order.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are the decisions our family thinks we are facing about my parent's long-term care:
>
> [PASTE YOUR LIST]
>
> Sort them into three groups: THE FAMILY CAN DECIDE THIS, A PROFESSIONAL SHOULD WEIGH IN FIRST, and NOT SURE. For the second group, say which kind of professional: a Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney, a licensed financial or insurance professional, a tax professional, or a care professional. Put anything that involves moving, gifting, or retitling money or property, signing legal documents, or the timing of a Medicaid application in the second group. Do not recommend what we should decide, and do not rank the decisions.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Decisions you were about to make alone that belong in the second group.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Hold the second group until you've spoken with the professional named beside each one.

PROMPT 4

Line up your questions for the right people

WHY THIS MATTERS

The most useful page to carry into a meeting shows where things stand and what you need answered, with each question beside the person who can answer it.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything I've organized about our family's situation:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Give me one page with four headings: WHAT WE KNOW, WHAT WE'VE BEEN TOLD (AND BY WHOM), WHAT WE DON'T KNOW, and QUESTIONS WE NEED ANSWERED. Under the last heading, mark each question with who should answer it: family, a Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney, a licensed financial or insurance professional, or not sure. Do not answer the questions, do not put steps in order, and do not say what we should do first.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

One page you could hand to a professional and have them see where things stand.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Keep the page. It's the start of the next step below.

Ready for the next step?

You've sorted what you know from what you've been told. The planning interview is the next step: it produces a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›